

GLOSSARY

Archipelago

A large group of islands.

Asteroid

A small, rocky planet orbiting the Sun.

Atmosphere

The thin layer of gases that surround Earth.

Climate

The typical weather recorded in a place over a period of 30 years or more.

Comet

An icy, rocky lump surrounded by a halo of gas and dust that orbits the Sun.

Communism

A system of government in which the state owns and controls everything on behalf of the people.

Continental plate

A tectonic plate that carries a continent.

Continental shelf

The gently sloping part of the ocean floor nearest to the shore.

Continental slope

The steep slope that leads from the continental shelf down to the continental rise and the seafloor.

Coral reef

An underwater structure formed by the accumulation of millions of coral polyp skeletons.

Crust

The hard outer shell of Earth.

Current

A mass of water flowing just below the surface of the ocean.

Delta

A fan-shaped, low-lying area of deposits at the mouth or end of a river.

Dictatorship

A form of government that has absolute control over a country, headed by a single individual, the army, or by a single political party.

Earthquake

A shaking of the ground caused by sudden movements in Earth's crust.

Eclipse

The total or partial covering of one heavenly body by another. A solar eclipse occurs when the Moon passes between the Sun and Earth; a lunar eclipse occurs when Earth passes between the Sun and Moon.

Equator

An imaginary line, midway between the two Poles, that divides the world into two equal halves, or hemispheres.

Fault

A crack or fracture in Earth's rocks caused by moving tectonic plates.

Geyser

A hot spring that throws up jets of boiling water and steam through a hole in Earth's crust.

Glacier

A moving river of ice.

Greenwich Prime Meridian

The line of 0° longitude, passing through Greenwich in London, from which the 24 time zones of the world are set.

Hemisphere

The northern or southern half of the world.

International Date Line

An imaginary line running down the length of the Pacific Ocean. When you cross it from west to east, you move the date on the calendar back one day to allow for the effect of the rotation of Earth around the Sun.

Landlocked

A country that has no access to the sea.

Latitude

The imaginary lines drawn parallel to the Equator that tell us how far north or south we are.

Lava

Magma that has emerged onto Earth's surface.

Longitude

The imaginary lines drawn around Earth from Pole to Pole that tell us how far east or west we are.

Magma

Hot, molten rock—created by the partial melting of Earth's crust and mantle—that emerges onto Earth's surface through a volcano.

Mantle

The soft interior of Earth that consists of solid rock and liquid magma and lies between Earth's core and its crust.

Monarchy

A kingdom or country whose head of state is a king or queen.

North Pole

The northern end of the axis around which Earth rotates.

Ocean

A vast, open expanse of seawater.

Ocean-basin floor

The deep part of the ocean beyond the continental shelf.

Ocean floor

All Earth's surface that is covered by water.

Oceanic plate

A tectonic plate that lies beneath an ocean.

Oceanic trench

A long, deep dip in the ocean floor.

Peninsula

A narrow strip of land projecting out into a sea or lake.

Planet

A celestial body that revolves around a star, from which it receives light; Earth is a planet that revolves around a star we call the Sun.

Republic

A country in which the people elect their head of state and government to rule them.

River basin

A dip or depression in Earth's surface that is drained by one river and its tributaries.

South Pole

The southern end of the axis around which Earth rotates.

Steppe

A grassy, largely treeless plain.

Tectonic plate

A plate that forms part of Earth's lithosphere – the rigid crust and upper mantle – and floats on the liquid mantle below.

Theocracy

A country that is ruled by religious leaders and religious laws.

Tornado

A small but intense spiraling windstorm formed beneath thunderclouds with wind speeds up to 250mph (400kph).

Tributary

A small river that joins a larger one.

Tropics

The area on either side of the Equator in which the midday Sun is generally overhead. The Tropic of Cancer is the line of latitude to the north of the tropics, the Tropic of Capricorn the line of latitude to the south.

Tsunami

A huge ocean wave set off by an underwater earthquake at sea.

Volcano

A gap in Earth's crust through which magma escapes.

Weather

A region's daily changes in factors such as wind, rainfall, and temperature.

